well-documented colonial/ imperial sympathies. This serves a dual purpose: through Porter, Sarna is able to reflect the growing opposition to British colonialism within a section of the British media and general populace. Also, it allows the novel to use Porter as a kind of surprise weapon throughout the narrative—because he has that duality within him, we are never quite sure of his motivations and how he will respond to a given situation on the day. According to Sarna, "Hugh Porter, the Chief Secretary of Punjab in the novel, is based on the real-life J.P. Thompson, but their characters are poles apart. Thompson was a dyed-in-the-wool arch imperialist; there were no grey areas in his head. Hugh Porter is more of a conflicted character and, as you know, in literature, it's the conflicted characters that tend to be interesting."

Another remarkable aspect of *Crimson Spring* is that while it does centre the narrative around Jallianwala on that fateful day, it also places into context the actions of all parties concerned—including Brigadier General Reginald Dyer, the man who gave the order to shoot on an unarmed peaceful crowd, killing hundreds. We are shown how larger socio-political forces around the world can have small, hyper-local consequences (a kind of reverse Butterfly Effect, if you will). For example, we are shown how the British government initiates a set of reforms in India, because they are increasingly losing the public perception battle back home in England. These sections could only have been written by someone with an instinctive understanding not only of politics and statecraft, but also of how the media often works in tandem with policymakers, either to 'manufacture' consent or deeply influence the same.

"In literature, it's the conflicted characters that tend to be interesting" –NAVTEJ SARNA

Describing Britain circa 1919, Sarna says: "At the time, there were very tiny attempts at reform by the colonial British government. You had the beginnings of the Montagu-Chelmsford Reforms (which were largely toothless but seen as major changes), plus the First World War had led to a situation where the contribution of Indian soldiers had to be recognised in some way." The chapter 'Sanction for Mass Murder', he adds, "sees this dilemma playing out between the liberal and conservative sections of the British politics and media".

Sarna is also a first-rate critic and has written essays on the life and works of several major writers—Truman Capote, Graham Greene, Amos Oz and many others. Starting from the late 2000s, Sarna wrote a literary column for *The Hindu* for several years. In 2015, HarperCollins collected these columns in the anthology *Second Life: On Books, Authors and the Writerly Life*. Sarna, in particular, admires Capote's style and the deftness with which the American writer turned real-life incidents into elegant, technically perfect narratives that were often marketed using the oxymoronic term 'nonfiction novel'.

"Capote was a tremendous stylist," Sarna says. "And I have always admired stylists, especially in the context of historical fiction. It's taken me years and years to learn what I have managed to learn about writing—starting from journalism and book reviews and moving on to novels. Style is what everybody strives for; it's what distinguishes you from everybody else who's telling the story. Otherwise, anyone can look up the facts and replay them in front of you." ■ **–Aditya Mani Jha**







(clockwise from top) Felice Beato's photograph of the Golden Temple; Emily Eden's portrait of Maharaja Ranjit Singh (c. 1838); a miniature painting of Mirabai surrounded by her disciples

Some of the most captivating pieces are from the reign of Maharaja Ranjit Singh (1780-1839)

Energetic commander, adept negotiator and liberal reformer, he embellished the Golden Temple, built palaces in Lahore and owned the eye-watering Koh-i-Noor. Prizes in the Khanuja collection include the maharaja's gold-inlaid swords and his quiver of arrows. Among several portraits is the famous image made shortly before his death by Emily Eden, Lord Auckland's waspish sister, whom he lavishly entertained. ("He is exactly like an old mouse, with grey whiskers and one eye," she tartly observed.)

The disintegration of the Sikh empire and takeover by the British (1845-46) did not take long. The shift in political power is brought alive through the lens of early photography. The Khanuja collection's cache of photographs and lithos capture the rapid conscription and deployment of Sikhs in British campaigns. One example is Felice Beato's arresting image of a fierce Akali at the 1885 relief of Gen. Gordon in Khartoum. Some 320,000 troops from Punjab later fought in the battlefields of the First World War.

If there is one major takeaway from this splendid volume, it is the nurturing space and investment extended by American museums to private collectors. State-owned Indian museums, often woefully maintained, offer no such incentive. A question mark now hangs over who gets Air India's valuable art collection. Given the track record of a government ministry versus the Tatas, the answer should really be a no-brainer. ■

–Sunil Sethi